

more social meeting forums where guest speakers are regularly invited to entertain and enlighten. Some clubs focus on each member's individual financial plan with an eye toward putting everybody's head together and suggesting ideas for improvement, and yet others allow members to maintain relative financial anonymity, focusing instead on broader financial concepts.

Given the wide range of clubs and activities available, here are a few guidelines if you want to start an investment club of your own.

1. Find some friends

The underlying tone of all investment clubs is a social one, so it is imperative that you enjoy the company of the other members! You don't necessarily need to know them all well—having friends recruit new members and accepting referrals can be quite effective—but you have to start somewhere.

Are you a new mom? Getting together with other new moms to form an investment club is a great way to socialize, and to learn about financial concepts that apply to your specific demographic.

Or maybe over drinks you and some other business owners in your

association tend to chat about money matters. Here is another like-minded group of people you could formalize the process with.

There is something to be said for attracting members with different backgrounds, too. The more diverse your club membership is, the more each person can bring to the table. So although everybody may have the common bond of being a new mom, colleague, or fellow business owner, hopefully there are also elements of diversity built in.

The way in which members must be on the same page, though, is with regard to financial philosophy. If one or two members only want to discuss short-term trading, and others want to discuss retirement plans or insurance, there will only be friction and disappointment on somebody's part.

2. Plan the meeting, and stick to an agenda

Ideally somebody can offer up their home or has a line on a quiet place to meet, where interruptions will be minimal and people can linger. Planning a meeting around food is always a great icebreaker, and sharing food tends to open people up to new ideas and conversation. Depending on the group size and dynamic, you can re-